against the Barbary pirates.[*] Moreover, of the conflicts known to us as "wars," three of the four most costly—measured by both life and money—have been undeclared: the Civil War, the Korean War, and now Vietnam. Had war begun in October 1962, its aftermath, perforce, would also have been undeclared.

The Civil War began, in Northern eyes, as a rebellion. In 1861, when South Carolina seized Fort Sumter, Congress was out of session with its Southerners beyond recall. Korea and Vietnam, however, are another matter: both were foreign wars and both began when Congress was in session. In 1950 and in 1965 the Presidents concerned did not apply to Congress. Instead they used their own command authority to send forces into war without a declaration. So did Nixon when our forces crossed the border of Cambodia. So would Kennedy have done, it seems, had there been a third week of crisis over Cuba.

Thirteen Days affords us many clues as to why modern Presidents have shied away from Congress in making decisions about war. One clue is *secrecy*. Before announcing the first step in his response, Kennedy could not disclose to anyone who lacked a rigid "need to know" what the U-2 had discovered. Had the discovery been widely known within the government, it would have leaked out. Had it leaked; the Administration's diplomatic initiative, achieved by making a countermove when unmasking Soviet duplicity, would have been lost. As it turned out, this was perhaps the best kept secret in American history. But only barely. By Saturday, James Reston of the *New York Times* had the story. A phone call from the President to his editor was necessary to delay the story until after the White House announcement.

A second clue is *flexibility*. It took extraordinary care and subtlety to find the "right" first-step response to Soviet missiles. Equal care was needed to design that step so that it signaled our intention to the Soviets, specified clearly what we wanted of Khrushchev, and left Kennedy poised for the next round. In that process, he could not commit himself to anyone without forfeiting maneuver room in dealing with Khrushchev.

Third, flexibility is compounded by *uncertainty*. Soviet intentions were the riddle to be read. These did not declare themselves with any blinding light like the Japanese attack in 1941. Uncertainty is compounded by *complexity*. To marshall our own forces and deploy them, and control them, to persuade our allies; to inform a hundred other governments through the United Nations; to say enough, but not too much in public; meanwhile trying to communicate effectually with Moscow—all this was to load a staggering burden on men already